



2 India are the form favourites to win

India were certainly the team causing the most commotion about and around T20 but a more dispassionate analysis of India's T20 international form would have shown that since its 2007 World T20 Championship win, at international level it has had an adverse win-loss record, two wins from five games. Dhoni denied that the Indians had spent two years stagnating in the format, citing the batsmen's collective collapse of 'form' as the overriding reason for India's anti-climactic performance in the World T20, saying he reckoned India needed to be at 90 per cent. "You have to be in peak form when conditions are too tough for batting, you have to be middling the ball from the go. The T20 format doesn't allow you to settle down and it's not like in Tests or ODIs where if you are struggling or playing to 60 per cent you can spend time getting in," Dhoni said, somehow managing to give to the T20 format an element of romantic struggle over other forms. It sounds like a persuasive reason but it does not explain how the men who struck 'form', aka got runs in practice games and against Bangladesh and Ireland, suddenly lost it in the next three games.



DEJECTED INDIAN PLAYERS AT THE DUGOUT; (LEFT) COACH GARY KIRSTEN BLAMED THE IPL FOR INDIA'S EARLY EXIT

clear-cut as it was with India. "Our performance," said captain M.S. Dhoni, "was not up to international standard" and he meant every word of it. Coach Gary Kirsten was fairly categorical too, saying that the Indians failed to generate "the level of intensity that you need to at the international game with the standard and quality of cricket (at the World Twenty20) obviously higher than what we would experience at the IPL". Every IPL team had four overseas players, maybe the same number of India internationals but the rest were domestic players and rookies. In the World T20, every player was an international quality cricketer, with a higher level of skill and free lunches were hard to find. South African Captain Graeme Smith said the IPL had "afforded us a wonderful opportunity to learn about the T20 game". Indeed. Everybody, it seems, benefited from the IPL barring Team India.

INDIA'S YOUNGSTERS FAILED TO DELIVER WHEN IT MATTERED MOST

1 The IPL has made Indian cricketers into T20 experts

The last fortnight in England provided a grim reminder—to players and fans—that more separates the Indian Premier League (IPL) and the global game than just salaries and the presence of Bollywood. The spread of quality bowling in an attack and the stakes involved meant that neither were runs so easy to come by against the frontline teams nor were there too many second chances. For the international players, every IPL team offered one if not two gimme bowlers. The sense of accountability for performance and result was not quite as

